Cashmere

LEADERSHIP BRIEF

Peacetime and wartime

What a startup learned from naming the shift, and why an industry can’t do it the same way.



SWIPE →

Ben Horowitz's two modes of leadership

PEACETIME

A large advantage in a growing market.

The CEO "strives for broad based buy-in."

WARTIME

"Fending off an imminent existential threat."

The CEO "neither indulges consensus-building nor tolerates disagreements."

Each demands a completely different way of operating.

THEIR PREVIOUS COMPANY

Default dead

The business had raised a lot of money and could afford to spend. The founders moved on, but the way they ran it stayed behind: deliberate, comfortable, consensus first. Nobody had done anything wrong.

The conditions had changed, and the company hadn't. It was a peacetime company in a wartime situation.



THE SLIDE

Naming the shift out loud

Jonathan Woahn and Jonathan Munk stood up in front of the whole company and named it: here's peacetime, here's wartime, here's how decisions get made now.

They put it all on a single slide. The slide wasn't really the point. Saying it out loud was.

VALUES ARE SUBJECTIVE TO THE NEEDS OF THE BUSINESS

Peacetime	Wartime
Deliberate culture	**Current conditions define the culture**
Annual planning	**One step at a time**
Well-defined & scalable processes	**Do things that don't scale**
Alignment > Speed	**Done > Perfect**
Crunchtime is planned	**Crunchtime as required**

What the reset changed

THE RESET

Here’s how we make decisions now, and here’s what we stop doing.

↓

WHAT CHANGED

Focus. Speed. Decisions. Some people who weren’t aligned with the new direction left.

↙ ↘

THE RESULT

Big-name clients, six-figure contracts, a growing business.

THE CAVEAT

Not a universal definition of wartime. It’s what it meant for a startup, at that moment.

Cashmere's own version of the tension

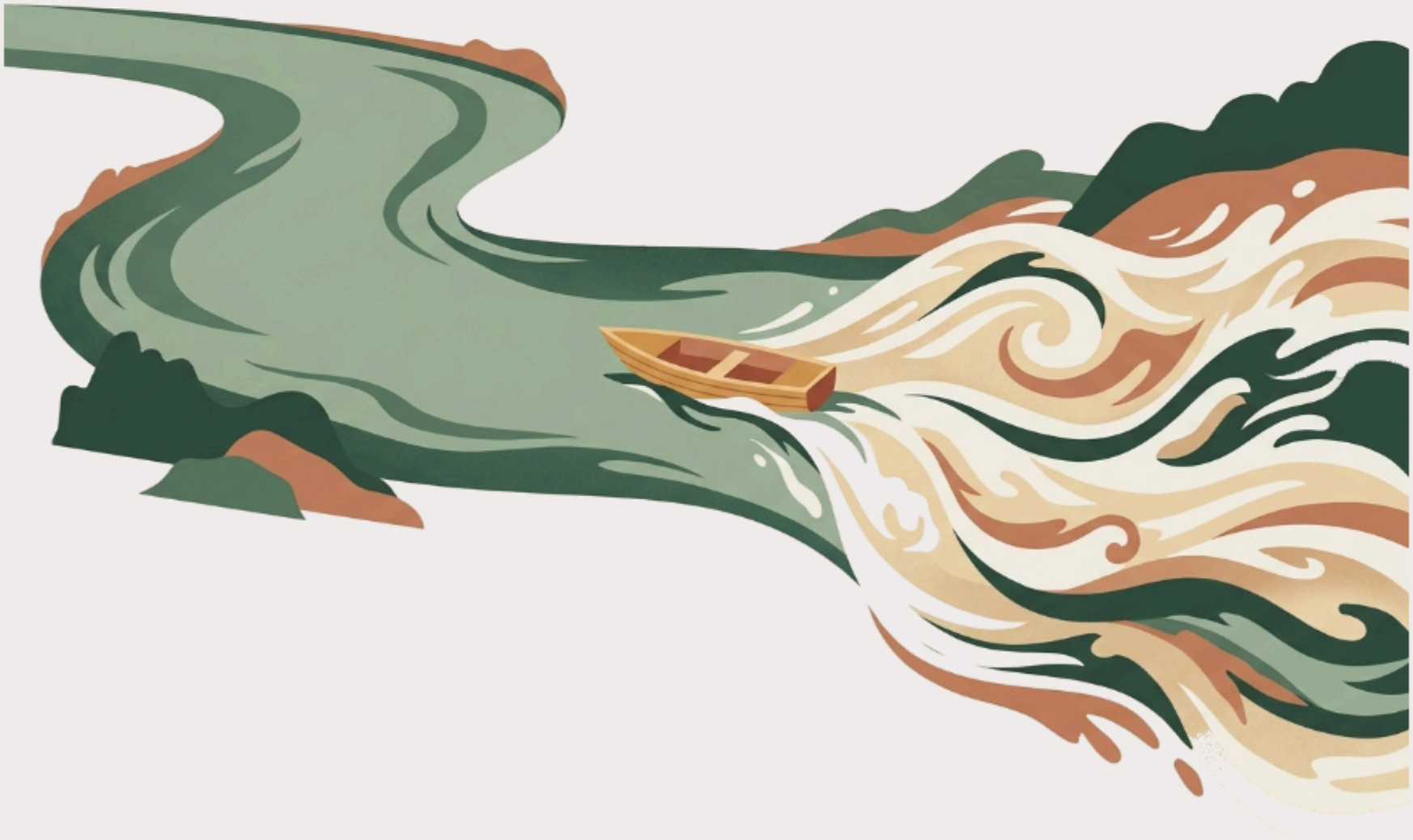
Buy-in, or no consensus-building. Peacetime, or wartime.

THE PULL TO COLLABORATE	The best way to build a movement is to bring people along, not hand them a blueprint. By nature, the team are collaborators.
THE PULL TO DICTATE	Years spent on how AI systems should access, license and pay for content. Data points that are battle-tested and well earned. The temptation is always there.

Publishing's conditions read like wartime

A threat to how content is discovered, accessed, and paid for. Business models that have held for generations, suddenly in question.

That's Horowitz's definition of wartime almost word for word.



AN ECOSYSTEM

Publishing isn’t a company. It’s an ecosystem.

Presses

- Its own board
- Its own mission
- Its own timeline

Societies

- Its own board
- Its own mission
- Its own timeline

Aggregators

- Its own board
- Its own mission
- Its own timeline

Libraries

- Its own board
- Its own mission
- Its own timeline

Getting all of them to recognize the moment, let alone move together, is a different problem entirely.

The answer isn’t to act like a startup.

A 500-year-old institution isn’t a twenty-person company with runway measured in months or years, and it shouldn’t pretend to be.

Cashmere

How much do we collaborate, and how much do we dictate?

Cashmere helps publishers make premium content AI-ready, governed, measurable, and monetizable.

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